



GDD 20 Defenders of the Body

Facts beat fear

The infections-and-stigma game for ages 9-12, built to the mechanic-embodiment standard. Children meet the body's defence team, learn how germs really spread (and don't), get the plain facts about HIV, and bust the myths that fuel stigma, choosing kindness over fear. Seven mechanics, 22 myth-flips, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Facts beat fear.

Defenders of the Body is the infections-and-stigma game. Children meet their immune system (the body's defence team), learn how germs actually spread and how to prevent them, get plain, age-right facts about HIV, and bust the myths that drive stigma, landing on kindness, not fear. It carries Smart Screen Heroes' "check the facts" instinct (g12) into health, and is the gentle on-ramp to the Sexual & Reproductive Health thread. New v2 build to the standard.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g20 · defenders-of-the-body (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 3 · ages 9-12 · light canvas · solo or peer
Thread / topics	F · Sexual & Reproductive Health · UNESCO 8.2, 8.3
Prerequisite / builds on	g19 (Speak Up) · builds on g12 (Smart Screen Heroes)
Gating	Core
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the infection-myth & stigma game.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

22

myth-flips

36

HIV facts & kindness

0%

binary taps

What spreads it, what doesn't.

The stigma-busting core, kept age-right for 9-12. The game puts the weight on what does not spread HIV, because that is what fights the fear.

HIV is NOT spread by

- Hugging, holding hands, shaking hands
- Sharing food, plates, cups or water
- Mosquito or insect bites
- Toilet seats, swimming, surfaces
- Coughs and sneezes (it isn't airborne)
- Sitting together, playing, being friends

HIV can spread by

- Blood, for example shared needles
- From a parent to a baby
- (Older children learn about other ways as they grow; this stays age-appropriate here.)

And the message that matters most: with daily medicine, people with HIV live long, healthy, normal lives, and children with HIV can safely go to school, play sport and do everything. You cannot tell who has HIV by looking, anyone can have it, and it is never a punishment or a person's fault.

The age fear gets learned.

From the Chapter 3 personas. By 9-12, children pick up scary, wrong ideas about illness, especially HIV, from rumours and overheard adults; this game replaces those with calm facts and kindness.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Asha, 24 (RKSK peer educator)	To deliver accurate, warm health facts as a near-peer.	strike-rewrite + match : the facts.
Diya, 11	To include a classmate with HIV without fear.	branch + role-play : include & reassure.
Aarav, 12	To replace overheard myths with real knowledge.	strike-rewrite : bust the myth.
Rohit (father)	Calm facts to share with worried elders.	branch : gently correct fear.
Every child	To know their own body defends them.	match + sort : the defence team.

Why this works (the evidence). HIV is not spread by hugging, sharing food, mosquito bites, toilet seats, coughs, or everyday school and play contact (CDC/NIH). It spreads through blood and certain body fluids, and with daily treatment people live long, healthy, normal lives. The immune system defends the body, good hygiene and vaccines prevent many infections, and HIV stigma is reduced by accurate facts plus including, not fearing, people living with HIV.

Seven moves, led by the flip.

The rework's heart: the science and the stigma-busting arrive through seven actions, and this is a game where **strike-rewrite** rightly leads, most fear about HIV is a myth waiting to be flipped to a fact. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE CHILD DOES	EMBODIES	N
strike-rewrite (myth-flip) signature	Erases an infection/HIV myth, writes the fact ("HIV from a hug" → never).	Conceptual change.	22
sort	Sorts spreads vs doesn't; helpful vs weak defence; fact vs myth.	Telling fact from fear.	16
branch	Decides how to act, include, correct a myth, wash hands.	Acting on facts.	12
reflect	Considers dignity, and that a person is more than a virus.	Empathy.	10
spot	Spots the germ-spreading move, or the myth on a chart.	Health literacy.	9
role-play (voice)	Stands up against stigma, "come sit with us".	Kindness in action.	8
match	Pairs a defender to its job; an infection to its route.	The science.	7

22 myths flipped and **20 of 84** moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the defenders → germs → prevent → HIV facts → myths → kindness arc, grounded in verified health facts. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
Your body's defenders	12	match, sort, strike-rewrite	Immune system: skin, white blood cells, fever, healing.
How germs spread	12	sort, spot, strike-rewrite	Air, water, hands; "only dirty people" myth busted.
Defend yourself	12	sort, branch, spot	Handwashing, covering coughs, clean water, vaccines.
HIV, simply explained	12	strike-rewrite, sort, branch	What HIV is; treatment = normal life; not a punishment.
Spreads, or doesn't?	18	strike-rewrite, sort, spot	Hugs, food, mosquitoes, toilets, play, friendship, all safe.
Kindness, not fear	18	branch, role-play, strike-rewrite	Include, reassure, defend dignity, keep health private.

A strike-rewrite scenario (spreads, or doesn't?), verbatim.

hook: "You can get HIV from hugging someone who has it."
 UN (erase): "Hugging someone with HIV can give you HIV."
 RE (write): "HIV is never spread by hugging; hug freely."
 why: "HIV isn't in everyday touch."

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 20 Defenders of the Body — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	FACT (RE WRITES)	BASIS
You can get HIV from a hug.	HIV is never spread by hugging; hug freely.	CDC/NIH.
Sharing food or a plate spreads HIV.	HIV does not spread through food, plates or cups.	CDC/NIH.
Mosquito bites can give you HIV.	Mosquitoes do not spread HIV at all.	CDC/NIH.
You can catch HIV from a toilet seat.	HIV is not spread by toilet seats or surfaces.	CDC/NIH.
HIV spreads through coughs like a cold.	HIV is not airborne; coughs and sneezes don't spread it.	CDC/NIH.
People with HIV are always sick.	With daily medicine, they live long, healthy, normal lives.	Treatment.
You can tell who has HIV by looking.	You cannot; people with HIV look like anyone else.	HIV basics.
HIV is a punishment for being bad.	HIV is just an infection, never a punishment.	Anti-stigma.

The micro-loop.

1. **Hook.** Lensy: "your body has a defence team, and a lot of scary 'facts' out there are myths".
2. **Play.** Meet a defender (match), sort spreads/doesn't, flip a myth, or choose kindness, rotated.
3. **The flip.** On a myth, UN strikes the fear and RE writes the fact ("from a hug" → never).
4. **Apply.** Include a classmate, correct a rumour, or say "come sit with us" in a role-play.
5. **Reflect.** "A person living with HIV is a whole person, not their virus."
6. **Sticker.** The Defender badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **spreads-or-doesn't sorter** and the **myth-flip card**, the same strike-and-rewrite engine the gender thread uses, here defending health facts and human dignity. Reused by Outbreak (g23) and the SRH thread.

Age-right, fear-free.

- **Register.** Ages 9-12, warm and matter-of-fact; Asha is the near-peer health guide, never alarmist.
- **Age-appropriate scope.** The "how HIV spreads" side stays at blood, needles and parent-to-baby; sexual transmission is deferred to Chapters 4-5, with an honest "you'll learn more as you grow".
- **Facts over fear.** The whole game tilts toward what's safe, because reducing fear is the point; nothing is sensationalised.
- **Never blame.** HIV and infections are framed as things that happen, never as a verdict on a person's character.
- **Dignity & privacy.** A person is more than their virus; health status is private, support not gossip.
- **Access.** Audio-first, offline; India-grounded (ASHA/RKSK, clean water); pairs with Smart Screen Heroes (g12) and Speak Up (g19).

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. defenders-of-the-body** — `node.game === GameDone` key === registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema.** Each scenario carries type + typed payload; **strike-rewrite** (myth: un / re / why) leads, with the **sort** spreads/doesn't board doing the stigma-busting work.
- **Fact-checked content.** HIV transmission facts verified against CDC/NIH; flag any future medical edits for re-verification.
- **Scorecard-gated.** Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, strike-rewrite at 26%, 0% binary, 20 autonomy, 22 UN→RE, 5 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Reuse.** The myth-flip and sort components are shared with Outbreak (g23) and the SRH thread; build once, reuse.
- **Generated path.** Label/order/thread changes flow through the `xlsx` + `gen-path`, never hand-edited `path.ts`.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): age-appropriate scope; facts over fear; never blame the person; protect dignity and privacy; medically verified; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Stigma is driven by myths, so facts dismantle it.** Because most fear of HIV comes from false beliefs about everyday transmission, a myth-flip game that replaces "from a hug" with "never from a hug" attacks stigma at its root, which is exactly UNESCO 8.2's stigma-reduction aim.
- **Knowing how germs really work builds calm competence.** Teaching the immune system and real transmission routes (air, water, hands, blood) lets children prevent infection sensibly and stop fearing the things that are actually safe.
- **Inclusion is taught, not assumed.** Pairing accurate facts with concrete kindness, "come sit with us", correcting a rumour, turns knowledge into the behaviour that actually reduces stigma for people living with HIV.

Sources: U.S. CDC (How HIV Spreads) and NIH HIVinfo (Understanding HIV Transmission); HIV-stigma education research. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 22 games now v2. Next in Chapter 3: the chapter capstone.